

India's Passport to Global Leadership

There is a new opportunity for India to build a global forum in Asia but for the world



THE STORY OF India and Davos has seven parts to it: the Opening, the Opportunity, the Objectives and Strategy, the Institutional Partnership, the Challenges, the India Team and finally, the New Opportunity.

224 | The Opening: The connect to CII (AIEI) in 1984 came from Rahul Bajaj, an early participant at Davos. The introduction to the World Economic Forum (WEF) that he made, and then monitored the progress, was the beginning of all that followed. From 1985 to 2025 there was a 40-year collaboration between WEF and CII, unique in the world.

The Opportunity: Slight signs of opening of the Indian economy were visible in the mid-'80s, but it seemed like an opportunity for CII to expand its reach to the world through WEF, having already built its international work through trade fairs, industry missions and overseas offices, and try to bring the world to India to support its growth. Only a few believed, then, that WEF could be a window for India, but the risk was taken. In retrospect, it was a good risk to take for India, the Indian economy and industry.

The Objectives and Strategy: The early objectives were to build interest in India, build its image, re-



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and
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lationships, confidence and investments. These never changed.

A dual strategy was followed. An annual India Economic Summit (IES) was held in partnership with WEF in Delhi in addition to participation in Davos. The WEF would bring foreign participants to the IES and CII would get Indian corporates to join WEF (as members) and participate in Davos, where business leaders of the world gathered. This collaboration rapidly evolved into including the Government of India and, later, the states. The strategy worked over time and, in the '90s, with the economic reforms of Manmohan Singh, the world beat a track to India. In the same period, the Indian interest in Davos was significantly enhanced, bordering on euphoria.

So, Davos became the platform for India to build its global image, expand its global network, consolidate its global influence and use this one place, high in the Alps, to take steps to become a global player.

Institutional Partnership: WEF and CII built a unique partnership, with WEF signing a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with CII, never done before with anyone else. The WEF organised an annual dinner for the Indian delegation on the opening day at Davos. WEF welcomed new member companies